

CHINA, HISTORY OF



CHINA IS THE WORLD'S oldest continuous civilization. For more than 2,000 years, from 221 BC to AD 1911, it was united as a single vast empire under a series of all-powerful rulers. During this period, borders changed, capitals shifted, and the country was invaded by fierce tribes, including the Mongols. However, for most of its history, China led the world in art and technology, with inventions including paper, porcelain, and gunpowder. Despite its huge size, a unique system of government and a strong sense of national identity have helped to maintain a united China.



Shang bronze ritual cauldron



Shang bronze staff-head

Ancient China

The first known Chinese dynasty, the Shang, ruled from about 1500 to 1027 BC. The Shang rulers were believed to be semi-divine, and were called the Sons of Heaven. It was their duty to maintain good relations between earth and the heavenly realm.



Qin Shi Huangdi

When Zheng (258–210 BC), the leader of the victorious Qin army, took control of China in 221 BC, he took the title of First Sovereign Qin Emperor, or Qin Shi Huangdi. The First Emperor treated his subjects harshly, and his dynasty was overthrown by a peasant rebellion in 207 BC. The name China comes from Qin.

Each soldier has a different face and is modelled on a real soldier.

Hollow body



Solid legs

Unification

By 400 BC, central government had broken down, and many small kingdoms fought among themselves. In 221 BC, the state of Qin emerged victorious, uniting all the rival kingdoms under the rule of the First Emperor. The Great Wall was built at this time, using slave labour.

Chinese civil service exam paper



Characters are read vertically.

Han Dynasty

In 207 BC, a new dynasty took power. The Han emperors, who ruled until AD 220, set up a national civil service to run the country. Officials studied the teachings of the philosopher Confucius (551–479 BC), and were selected by a rigorous examination system. The structure of the civil service remained largely unchanged for 2,000 years. The Han reign marked a period of peace and prosperity.

Terracotta army

The First Emperor's tomb was guarded by thousands of life-sized terracotta warriors with horses and chariots, whose job was to protect the emperor in the afterlife. This terracotta army was found in 1974 by men digging a well. The tomb lies near to the modern-day city of Xian.

The soldiers once carried real weapons made of bronze, but these were stolen by grave robbers.

Great Wall



First empire

Protected by the Great Wall, the Qin empire covered what is now northern and eastern China. The wall was built as a defence against hostile tribes from Central Asia.

Inventions

Throughout Chinese history, emperors encouraged the development of science and technology. Paper and printing, gunpowder, harnesses for animals, the magnetic compass and stern rudder, and the wheelbarrow were all invented in China.

15th-century gun



Shield protects soldier.

Multiple gun fires a hail of bullets.

Bronze "knife coins"



Paper money

The Chinese perfected paper-making in about AD 105, using pulped silk waste. In later years, hemp, bark, or bamboo were used. The development of printing followed, and paper money was first circulated in China in the 9th century. By this time, the Chinese were also printing books using carved wooden blocks.



Gunpowder

Chinese scientists first produced gunpowder in the 9th century, and soon adapted their technology to make fireworks and weapons. Early Chinese rockets, fuelled by gunpowder, were in use by the 13th century. The Chinese also invented the gun, the bomb, and the mine.

Chinese character, or symbol, which translates to mean "happiness and good fortune".



Three perfections

The Chinese call calligraphy, poetry, and painting "the three perfections". From the Song dynasty (960–1279) onwards, the combination of these three disciplines in a single work of art was considered to be the height of artistic expression, and to be skilled in them was seen as the greatest accomplishment of an educated person. Calligraphers spent many months practising the brushwork of just one or two characters.